

Ada and the Water of Coyote Creek

Cowboy story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1: Dust on the Horizon

Heat shimmered above the parched plains, blurring the distant outline of Coyote Creek. The wind tugged at Ada Sullivan's hat, whipping strands of sun-bleached hair across her face. She tightened her grip on the reins of her old paint horse, Scout, eyes narrowed against the glare.

"Don't look now, Scout," Ada muttered, "but trouble's blowing in faster than a jackrabbit on the run."

Scout snorted as if to say, "Don't I know it."

Up ahead, a wooden sign creaked on a splintered post: "Welcome to Coyote Creek. Water's for the worthy." Ada squinted. The sign was new—and trouble in itself. Ever since Old Man Walker had struck water on his ranch, the town was divided. Some had plenty. Others had none.

She spurred Scout forward, past the empty troughs and dusty hitching rails. Folks glanced up from porches, suspicion and hope wrestling in their eyes. Ada dismounted in front of the general store, her boots stirring a swirl of red dust.

Inside, the place buzzed like a beehive. Farmer Green's voice rode above the rest: "We can't just let them take what we've worked for! Water's gold here!"

Someone else countered, sharp: "And if we don't share, our neighbors won't last through the summer!"

Ada stepped forward. "Maybe there's a better way than fighting over every drop."

Chairs scraped. Eyes settled on her—some wary, some desperate, some downright hostile.

A girl with red braids piped up from a corner, “You got a plan, Ada?”

Ada nodded, heart thumping like hooves on hardpan. “I do. But I’ll need help. And courage. And maybe a little luck.”

Chapter 2: The Rail Splitter’s Dilemma

Later that afternoon, Ada slipped into the shadow of the old barn, where her friend Deputy Jesse Martin waited. He was tall and wiry, with a grin that could disarm a rattlesnake.

“Town’s buzzing,” Jesse said. “You sure you want to throw yourself into this mess?”

Ada laughed, low and defiant. “If we don’t fix things, there’ll be more than mess—there’ll be misery.”

Jesse shook his head. “Walker won’t share a drop. He locked his whole ranch up tighter than a bank vault.”

Ada reached into her satchel, pulling out a crumpled map. “That’s why we need to show him—and everyone else—there’s enough to go around. What if we built a channel from his spring, one that feeds every ranch?”

Jesse whistled, low. “You want to dig a canal? That’s half a mile through hard earth.”

Ada’s grin flashed. “We don’t have to do it alone. The whole town could lend a hand—if we can convince them to work together.”

Jesse’s eyes sparked. “It’s a mighty big ‘if.’ Folks think sharing means losing.”

Ada folded her arms. “Then we’ll have to prove them wrong. But first, we’ll need

permission from Walker. And that'll take some clever talking."

Scout nickered outside, as if adding, "And a heap of nerve."

Chapter 3: Parched Arguments

The next morning, Ada approached Walker's ranch, dust curling beneath Scout's hooves. The fence loomed tall, the gate chained and padlocked. Two burly ranch hands eyed her suspiciously.

"State your business," one grunted.

Ada pushed back her hat. "I'm here to speak to Mr. Walker."

The man's brow furrowed. "He don't meet with just anyone."

Ada fixed him with a steady stare. "He'll want to meet with me. It's about water."

That did it. Minutes later, Ada stood in a cool parlor, face-to-face with Old Man Walker—a wiry figure with sharp blue eyes and a beard like tumbleweed.

"Ada Sullivan," he drawled. "Figured you'd come asking for handouts."

Ada shook her head. "Not handouts. A fair solution. The land's dying, and so are your neighbors' herds. What good is water if you stand alone?"

Walker snorted. "I worked for what I have. No one handed me nothing."

Ada's voice softened. "No one's asking you to give it away. But if we build a channel, everyone gets enough. You'll still have plenty. And maybe next drought, your neighbors will remember who stood by them."

Walker's eyes narrowed, searching her face for a trick. At last, he sighed. "You've got more spine than most men I know. But I won't risk my ranch unless every soul in town promises to do their part. I won't lift a finger till then."

Ada nodded. "I'll get their word."

As she rode away, Ada knew the hardest part was just beginning.

Chapter 4: The Long Dry Walk

With Jesse by her side, Ada visited every homestead from sunrise to sundown. The sun beat down, cruel and relentless. At each place, she explained Walker's condition: everyone must swear to help dig and maintain the new channel, and to share the water equally.

Some slammed their doors. Others laughed in her face.

"Why trust Walker?" barked Mrs. Quinn, broom in hand. "He's only looking out for himself!"

Ada wiped sweat from her brow. "He's giving up some of his water. That's a start. Someone's got to be first to trust, or none of us will make it."

A pale boy pulled at his mother's sleeve. "Mama, can we try? I'm so thirsty."

The words hung in the air. One by one, the townsfolk began to listen. Ada used every bit of her wit—sometimes cajoling, sometimes joking, sometimes just listening to their worries.

Jesse kept a tally. "Seventeen promises so far. We need all forty."

By nightfall, Ada's boots were worn thin, but her spirit held strong.

"We'll go again tomorrow," she told Jesse. "Nobody said courage was easy."

Chapter 5: Sabotage at Midnight

That night, as Ada checked on Scout in the stable, she caught a shadow darting between the stalls. Breath stilled, she eased her way forward.

Someone's tampering with the tools, she realized.

She lunged, grabbing a wiry arm. "Not so fast!"

The stranger twisted free and dashed outside. Ada chased him into the moonlit yard, where Jesse joined her, lantern swinging.

"Who was that?" Jesse panted.

Ada frowned, picking up a spade—its handle freshly sawed, ready to snap. "Someone trying to stop us before we start."

The next morning, word spread of missing tools, broken shovels, and water barrels overturned. Some folks were scared. Others grew angry.

Ada climbed onto a wagon and called out, "Whoever's trying to stop us is afraid. Afraid we'll succeed. But I'm not afraid. Are you?"

A murmur ran through the crowd. The red-haired girl from the store shouted, "We're with you, Ada!"

Ada's heart swelled. "Then let's get to work. Together."

Chapter 6: The Dig

For days, the town was alive with clatter and grit. Men, women, and even children swung pickaxes, heaved shovels, and passed water skins hand to hand. Ada worked at the front, muscles burning, face streaked with sweat and dust.

Jesse laughed, “Never thought I’d see Mrs. Quinn swinging a pickaxe next to Walker himself.”

Ada grinned, teeth white in a face brown with dirt. “The West does strange things to folks.”

They hit rocks and roots, blisters blooming on their palms. When tempers flared, Ada cooled them off with jokes or a knowing look.

At midday, someone yelled, “The spring! We’ve hit the spring!”

Water gushed into the channel, sparkling in the sun. The crowd cheered, dirty faces breaking into smiles.

But then the channel started to crack in the midday heat, and a shout rang out: “The water’s running too fast! It’ll break the bank!”

Ada shouted commands. “Pile up the rocks! Slow the flow!”

Everyone rushed to strengthen the banks with stones and wood. Ada wrestled a boulder into place, teeth gritted. At last, the torrent slowed, and the channel held.

Jesse clapped her on the back. “That was close.”

Ada nodded, heart pounding. “But we did it. Together.”

Chapter 7: The House with Open Doors

With the channel finished, Coyote Creek changed. Water flowed to every field, every trough, every kitchen. The drought eased its grip, and life returned—green and blooming.

One evening, Ada found Walker standing before his door, a pensive look softening his sharp features.

“I was wrong about you, Ada,” he said quietly. “And maybe about this whole town.”

Ada smiled. “Respect doesn’t mean agreeing on everything. It means seeing each other as neighbors, not enemies.”

Walker nodded, then surprised her by opening his door wide. “Come inside. I’m hosting supper for anyone who helped dig. Neighbors shouldn’t just share water—they should share their table.”

Soon, every seat in his house was full. Laughter and stories flowed as freely as the water outside. Ada sat at the long table, Scout chewing hay outside the window.

Jesse raised a glass. “To Ada—for showing us the West is big enough for all of us, if we have the grit to work together.”

The crowd echoed, “To Ada!”

Ada blushed, but her eyes sparkled. She looked around at the faces—tired, proud, bound by a new respect.

Maybe the West was wild and harsh, but here, beneath the wide sky, folks had chosen a different way.

A way of courage, intelligence, and resilience. And, above all, a way of respect.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What was Ada's main goal in the story?

- To win a race
- To find a lost treasure
- To bring water to the town
- To defeat Old Man Walker

2) Why did the townsfolk initially not trust Ada's plan?

- They didn't like her idea
- They were afraid of hard work
- They thought Walker was greedy
- They didn't want to share anything

3) What did Ada find when she confronted Old Man Walker?

- He wanted to fight her
- He agreed to share his water
- He was not home
- He asked her to leave

4) What happened when the water first flowed through the channel?

- It flooded the entire town
- It broke the bank and started flowing too fast
- It stopped suddenly
- It ran perfectly without any problems

5) How did the townsfolk finally come together?

- By organizing a festival
- By digging the canal together
- By competing against each other
- By ignoring each other

6) At the end of the story, what did Walker do that showed he had changed?

- He closed his doors
- He threw a party for the townsfolk
- He refused to help anymore
- He left Coyote Creek

Correct answers:

1) To bring water to the town 2) They thought Walker was greedy 3) He agreed to share his water 4) It broke the bank and started flowing too fast 5) By digging the canal together 6) He threw a party for the townsfolk

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Parched: Extremely dry due to lack of water.

Cajoling: Persuading someone to do something by coaxing or flattery.

Torrent: A sudden and fast flow of water.

Blisters: Small bubbles filled with fluid that form on the skin from burns or friction.

Pensive: Engaged in deep or serious thought.

Resilience: The ability to recover quickly from difficulties or setbacks.